

 **The Sport Industry
Report 2026**



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FOREWORD



Nick Keller, Chairman,
Sport Industry Group



Confidence in growth - with caution

With the global sport industry forecast to reach £862 billion annually by 2033, growing at a 7% CAGR, there is understandable optimism across the sector. That confidence is reflected in our findings, with 71% of fans and 74% of industry professionals feeling positive about the future of sport.

However, the data suggests that the next chapter of sport cannot be driven by financial metrics alone: it must be guided equally by purpose, integrity, and the long-term wellbeing of the communities it serves.

Affordability and access: Sport must not become a luxury

One of the most pressing concerns emerging from this year's research is affordability. In a world increasingly shaped by short-term thinking and economic pressure, sport risks drifting towards becoming a luxury product rather than a shared cultural experience.

Sport has always been at its best as a level playing field - accessible, inclusive, and deeply embedded in communities. Yet rising ticket prices and pay-TV subscriptions, in addition to increasing costs at grassroots level are creating real barriers. 67% of fans and over 50% of professionals believe attending live sport will become a luxury within the next five years.

Sport thrives when it is profitable, but its long-term value is built through inclusion. Sustainable growth will come not from exclusivity, but from widening access and participation.

Responsibility beyond the field of play

The belief that sport has a broader role to play in society is overwhelming. Over 72% of fans and 75% of professionals believe sport carries a greater responsibility than other industries to drive positive change.

That responsibility extends to access. 78% of fans and 89% of professionals believe governing bodies - and government - should play a central role in guaranteeing participation and protecting free-to-air access. Over the next decade, this will likely drive deeper public-private partnerships, as sport increasingly helps address societal challenges such as isolation, mental health, and social connectivity.

Sport's ability to influence behaviour is also clear. 27% of fans say they have changed their behaviour following a campaign delivered through sport - an extraordinary reminder of the platform sport provides, and why access matters so deeply.

Women's sport: Momentum that must be built upon

Women's sport continues to show strong momentum. 32% of fans say their interest has grown in the past year. Greater visibility and accessibility are clearly having an impact.

At the same time, the data remains realistic. Only 30% of fans and 10% of professionals currently say they would prefer to watch women's sport over men's. This reinforces the need to position women's sport not as a replacement, but as a distinct and compelling proposition.

The next stage of growth will require sustained investment into assets, storytelling, and

community-led programming. Done well, this will build deeper fan bases and create long-term value for the industry as a whole.

Technology, culture and the future fan

Attitudes toward social media are shifting rapidly. 80% of fans and 92% of professionals believe there should be restrictions on social media use for under-16s - a significant moment for an industry that has invested heavily in engaging young fans in digital spaces.

While television remains the primary medium for fans to follow live sport, culture, commentary, and community increasingly exist online. How sport navigates this balance - between innovation, protection, and connection - will be critical.

Technology, and particularly AI, is firmly on the agenda. Both fans and professionals believe innovation will enhance the sporting experience overall.

However, adoption of new technology should also ensure that we don't remove the joy of sport and its ability to see humanity at its best, where - despite varying levels of capability and skill - resilience and grit can change the outcome. That story is why sport as a platform is unmatched.

This year promises unforgettable sporting moments, from the daring feats of the Winter Olympics and the global spectacle of the FIFA World Cup to the gut-wrenching, eye-catching, table-turning drama of the Premier League, Wimbledon, the Six Nations, Formula 1, and countless other competitions. With all that's happening in the world, thank goodness for sport.